

Introduction

Kenneth L. Fisher

This is among the most beloved investment books of all times, among the bestselling of classic investment books, and now forty-five years old. My father wrote his original preface at my childhood home in September 1957. It remains herein. Forty-five years later in October 2002, in my current home, I dare write this, this book's first new preface in all those decades.

If you've read my revised preface, you might think my father is deceased. No. As I write, he is ninety-five and alive. But he is reduced by the awesome wreckage induced by late stages of aged senile dementia and probably by Alzheimer's disease (there is no right way to be sure). He is at home, in bed, about thirty feet away from where he wrote *Common Stocks and Uncommon Profits* and his other writings.

He deteriorates steadily. To those few of us taking care of him, it is startlingly quickly. By the time you read this, he may well be deceased. He will never read these words—were they read to him, he couldn't follow their meaning for more than a sentence or two before losing the thread in dangling disconnects cut by his dread disease. He was a great man but is now just a little, old man very late in life. But he is my little, old man. What this disease routinely does to people is nothing to be ashamed of; it is just a disease, not a failing. When I wrote my third book, based on one hundred cameo biographies of dead pioneers of American finance, I defined it as “dead” pioneers only on the premise that dead people don't sue, just in case I got anything wrong. But I also did so because I purposefully didn't want to cover my father in any regard. I didn't want to say anything that might hurt him if I interpreted him differently than he might have wished, which I well might have.

Now I need not worry about that because he won't know what I say here. So it is time to tell you a bit about the man who wrote one of the best beloved investment books of all time. I'm best qualified to do so because I know him better than anyone if you combine business and personal matters. Oh, certainly, in other ways my mother, his wife, knew him far better than